The Last Lamp

A short test book for Spoken Margins. Its four chapters are bookmarks only: no page prints a chapter heading. The app's chapter list should show the four bookmark names.

Every evening at dusk the keeper climbed the ninety steps and lit the lamp. He had done it for eleven years, and in all that time no ship had come close enough to need it. He kept a ledger anyway, writing the weather and the hour in a small, careful hand. On the night this story begins, the ledger said only: wind from the north, sea calm, a light seen far out where no light should be. He watched it for an hour before it went out, and then he sat with the pencil in his hand and did not write anything at all.

The supply boat came on the first of each month, carrying flour, lamp oil and letters. This month it carried a passenger, a surveyor named Ada with a case of brass instruments and a habit of asking questions that had no easy answers. She wanted to know why the lamp was lit when the shipping lane had moved twenty miles south. The keeper said it was his job. She said that was not the same thing as a reason, and wrote something in her own ledger, which was much larger than his.

Ice closed the harbour in December and the supply boat stopped coming. Ada stayed, because there was no way to leave, and the two of them settled into a routine of measurements and arguments. She measured the tides and the stars. He measured the oil, which was running low. By February they had stopped arguing about whether the lamp mattered and started arguing about how long it could last. The light far out at sea came back twice that winter, and both times they watched it together without saying a word.

When the ice broke in April, the supply boat returned with a new keeper and a letter closing the station. The lamp would be dark by summer. Ada packed her instruments and offered him a place on the boat. He climbed the ninety steps one more time, lit the lamp, and wrote in the ledger: wind from the south, sea calm, no light seen. Then he closed the book, left it on the table for whoever came next, and went down to the water.